provide information of the eight state transport undertakings (STUs) and their daily/ monthly performance. With over 22,000 buses and a large number of scheduled services, even a minor disruption is reflected on the dashboards. Tracking the operations reveal that the Metropolitan Transport Corporation's (MTC) daily revenue per bus is considerably lower than many of the others. MTC has a larger number of women commuters than other STUs, which brings down the daily revenue (women travel free on STU buses, one of Stalin's first decisions on becoming CM).

Many of the dashboards provide daily updates, others at longer intervals, some even monthly. It's also possible to pull up work-related progress data from the departments. Currently, there are 490 panchayats, 138 municipalities and 20 municipal corporations on the dashboards. Before the dashboards, no project monitoring tool existed to track public infrastructure projects (nothing anyway that provided real-time data).

Civil works taken up by local urban bodies are now monitored from start to finish at 14 different stages. Stalin views these dashboards often for a direct understanding of the status of works in urban local bodies. Over 15,000 photographs are also captured on these dashboards, enhancing the integrity of the data. What is covered extensively on the department dashboards is available in a concise format on just two screens of the CM's dashboard. If he needs more details, they are made available in an instant.

The evolution of the 'CM Dashboard Tamil Nadu 360' has not been easy. "Our challenge is in keeping it as simple and as incisive as possible, which is why we try to get the key performance indicators (KPIs) on one screen," says Davidar, adding that "several departments worry as we are not keen about the narrative but about the outcome". The initial fears about being perceived in a negative light are receding in the administration as government employees understand that dashboards are useful governance tools and 'masking' of data is a risky proposition.

For long, departments worked in silos with the heads reluctant to share data with other departments. They now appreciate the value of data-driven governance. "Dashboards bring all schemes and their status on one particular platform. What this implies is that, as heads, we have to come up with timelines for each project, from giving administrative sanction, calling for tenders, settling tenders and setting other milestones," says B. Chandramohan, principal secretary, tourism, culture and religious endowments department. "The dashboards have become an overarching project management system that is reviewed at the highest level. This is for the first time such a thing is being attempted and it will help us perform and deliver better."

Senior bureaucrats are now able to monitor and review where a department project is heading, without having to wait for a review meeting. They have begun to appreciate that dashboards provide information that helps in understanding the big picture. There is even a facility to look at detailed information district-wise if the CM, ministers or senior officers want it to assess current and emerging scenarios, or even for comparisons. The State Planning Commission is also using the dashboards to bring greater clarity in evolving policies, plans and discussions on issues of governance relating to different departments. The CM's dashboard is accessible to the departments, and hence allows for 'benchmarking' between government bodies and districts, panchayats and municipalities. This, in turn, helps them focus on areas and operations that need improvement.

There is guarded optimism in Fort St George that these dashboards could change the face of "administrative delivery" across Tamil Nadu. As an internal governance tool, it is also ushering in greater accountability in reporting and analysing KPIs of diverse departments. In the coming years, this could entail a transformation of government processes and also see a migration of paper-based file processing to e-offices. ■

DASHBOARD DELIVERY



➘ CM Stalin closely tracks the **REVENUE DEPARTMENT**, which processes 27 citizen-centric certificates. Pendency is a concern and Stalin's watch has helped speed up disposal. Data revealed that 800-odd posts of land surveyors were lying vacant, leading to delays. The CM has asked for posts to be filled by mid-2023.



➘ Textiles hub **TIRUPPUR'S CRIME RATE** has been high and data showed that while original residents numbered just 500,000, migrant workers had swelled the population to 1.4 million. The 13 police stations were not enough to cover the region. The number of stations have been increased and staff strength beefed up.

...AND THE NUMBERS

103 dashboards covering activities of different departments and flagship programmes are onboard now

By March-end, all 38 departments and the 220 directorates will have dashboards

₹18.5 crore allocated over three years to formulate the templates for the dashboards